

Justice as fairness



One of the central concerns of Socrates's discussions in the time of the classical Greek philosophers was the definition of justice, and in the 1970s philosophers revisited this idea in the light of American capitalist democracy. Among them was John Rawls, who put the case for liberalism with his definition of 'justice as fairness'. In explanation, Rawls described a thought experiment known as the 'veil of ignorance', in which participants create an imaginary society from scratch – an 'original position' – and choose the distribution of rights, resources and positions in the society they will then live in. However, the veil of ignorance prevents them from

knowing anything about their own abilities, intelligence, social standing, or wealth, so personal considerations of their own place in the new society do not affect their judgement. They are forced to consider the new society from the perspective of benefit to *all* members of the society, regardless of their standing, and justice is achieved by a fair distribution.